At another level of analysis – that of the historic-concrete formations subject to imperialist relations – the word *dependency,* devised by Marxist Dependency Theorists (MDTs), gained currency as an analytical category. It was thought of as a necessary complement to the theory of imperialism. Laying the bases for the study of Latin American capitalism, the Marxist dependency theorists revealed the laws of operation of this *sui generis* capitalism and shared in the effort of establishing Marxism on the continent (Ferreira and Luce 2012). Among them was Ruy Mauro Marini who, by analysing the changes in the capitalist world system during the 1960s and 1970s, identified the emergence of sub-imperialism as a new stage of dependent capitalism by means of the coming-of-age of a new type of socio-economic formation that, in Latin America, took shape in Brazil.

Today it is commonplace to use the word 'sub-imperialism' to characterise 'emerging' sub-powers' economic and political expansion into other historical and geographical contexts, for example the relationship of South Africa with its neighbours, that of India in its region, Brazil in South America and even that of China (which is beyond the category of sub-imperialism) on the African continent. The few translations of Marini's original work into other languages have difficulty amplifying and deepening the studies of the category sub-imperialism.[2]

Our purpose in this chapter is not to evaluate or review studies of the BRICS group but rather to discuss Marini's category by reflecting upon his proposal within the Marxist tradition. At the same time, it is hoped, by means of Marini's category of sub-imperialism, to introduce elements that will confer greater rigour on the analyses, which frequently erase the required differentiation between such very disparate economies and socio-economic formations as those under the umbrella of the BRICS acronym.[3] The argument is that the foundations of a global theory of sub-imperialism are discernible in Marini's books and dozens of articles on Brazilian and Latin American capitalism. If, on the one hand, these elements are dispersed in the totality of Marini's writings with no text where the author's final word on the category's significance can be found, on the other hand its systematisation can be accomplished with rigour, provided that one respects the categorial connection tying his propositions on sub-imperialism to MDT theoretical works. These include the laws of dependent capitalism (over-exploitation of the workforce, value transfer, rifts between the phases of the capital reproduction cycle) and other notions and categories developed by him and other MDT exponents, especially those of the capital reproduction pattern and antagonistic cooperation and the typology of socio-economic formations within dependent industrialisation.